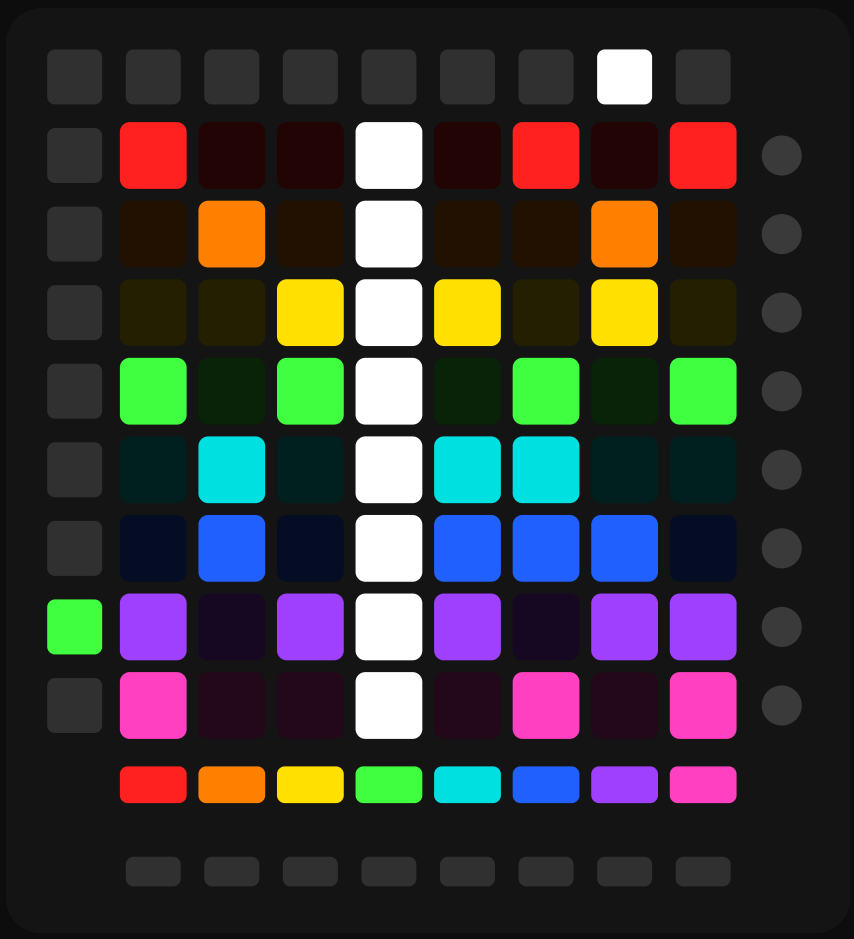
USER GUIDE

8-Track Sequencer

Standalone firmware for Launchpad Pro MK3



Early beta - flash at your own risk. Community firmware based on CoreFW (GPL-3.0). Not made, endorsed or supported by Novation or Focusrite. Launchpad and Launchpad Pro are trademarks of Focusrite Audio Engineering Ltd, used here only to identify the hardware.

Contents

1 Introduction

2 Overview

3 Getting Started

4 Programming Steps

5 Tracks

6 Patterns and Chains

7 Tempo, Swing and Playback

8 Live Recording

9 MIDI Thru

10 MIDI Clock

11 Projects

12 Quick Reference

13 Installing the Firmware

SECTION 1

Introduction

The 8-Track Sequencer turns a Launchpad Pro MK3 into a standalone MIDI sequencer. It runs on the Launchpad itself – no computer is needed once it is installed. Connect synths and drum machines to the two DIN MIDI outputs (or to a computer over USB) and program up to eight parts at once.

Key features

- **8 tracks**, each with its own MIDI channel, output (USB, DIN 1, DIN 2 or both DIN outs), note range, transpose and step rate (1/32 to a whole bar, including triplets)
- **8 patterns per track** (A–H) of up to **64 steps**, switched and chained independently per track
- **Chords** – up to 8 notes on every step
- Per-step **velocity**, **gate length** and **probability**
- Tempo 30–300 BPM with **tap tempo** and an on-grid **BPM readout**; **swing** from 50 % to 75 %
- **Live recording** from the pads or an external keyboard, quantised to the nearest step
- **MIDI thru**: a keyboard plays whichever track is selected
- Sends **MIDI clock**, or follows an external clock from USB or DIN In
- **8 project slots** saved in the Launchpad's memory
- Playback continues while you use the Launchpad's Note mode

What you need

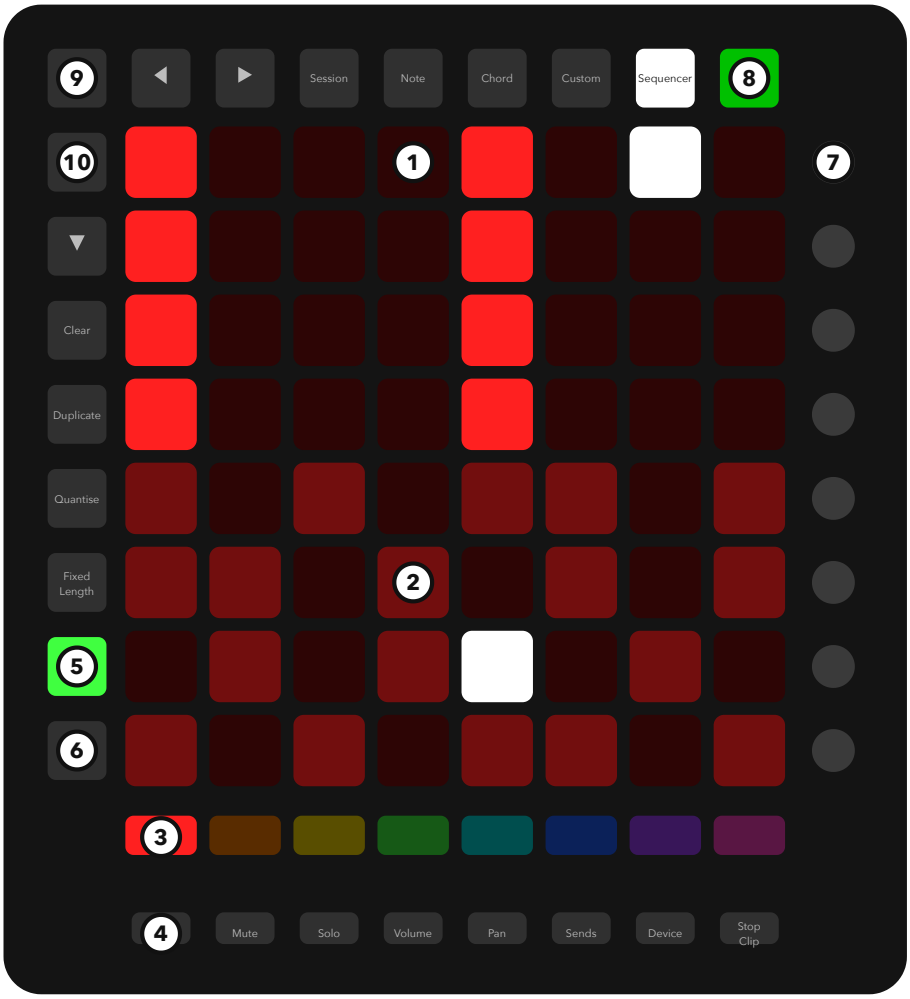
- A Launchpad Pro MK3 running the sequencer firmware (see *Installing the firmware* at the end of this guide)
- Synths, drum machines or a computer to play, connected to **MIDI Out**, **MIDI Out 2** or USB
- Optionally, a MIDI keyboard on **MIDI In** or the USB MIDI port

> **NOTE**
> The second DIN socket on the back of the Launchpad is used as **MIDI Out 2** by this firmware (not as MIDI Thru).

SECTION 2

Overview

The sequencer uses the whole surface of the Launchpad. The top half of the grid shows the steps of the selected track; the bottom half is a keyboard of 32 notes. The coloured row under the grid selects tracks and the row beneath that mutes them.



The sequencer with track 1 selected and playing

1. **Step area.** 32 steps of the selected track's current pattern: steps 1–32, or 33–64 after ▶ (top row = steps 1–8 or 33–40). Lit steps play; brighter = louder. The white pad is the playhead.
2. **Note area.** 32 chromatic notes, lowest at the bottom left. Tap a note to hear it and to choose the note new steps get.
3. **Track buttons.** Tap to select a track, hold for its settings. Each track has its own colour.
4. **Mute buttons.** Record Arm … Stop Clip mute tracks 1–8. While a step is held they set its gate length.
5. **Play.** Start / stop. Green = internal clock, cyan = following an external clock.
6. **Record.** Arm live recording.
7. **Patterns.** Hold to show the pattern map for all eight tracks.
8. **Projects.** Tap to save, hold to load. Green = saved, amber = unsaved changes.
9. **Shift.** Hold for tempo, swing, tap tempo and the clock setting.
10. **▲ / ▼.** Move the note area up or down an octave.

Entering and leaving the sequencer

Press **Sequencer** to open the sequencer. The first time after power-up, the last project you used is loaded automatically.

Press **Note** to return to the Launchpad's Note mode. **Playback keeps going** while you play in Note mode – the **Sequencer** button lights green to show it. Press **Sequencer** again to come back.

SECTION 3

Getting Started

This walkthrough programs a simple pattern and plays it on a synth connected to **MIDI Out**.

1. Connect your synth's MIDI In to the Launchpad's **MIDI Out** socket, and set the synth to receive on **MIDI channel 1**.
2. Press Sequencer. Track 1 (red) is selected. New tracks send on **MIDI Out**, with the MIDI channel equal to the track number.
3. Tap a pad in the note area. You hear the note on your synth – it is now the note new steps will use.
4. Tap steps 1, 5, 9 and 13 in the step area to turn them on.
5. Press ▷ (Play). The playhead moves across the steps and the synth plays.
6. Hold step 5 and tap two more note pads: step 5 is now a three-note chord.
7. Tap track button 2 (orange), choose a note and add some steps. Track 2 plays on MIDI channel 2.
8. Tap Projects to save. The button flashes white, then turns green.

> **TIP**
> Hold **Shift** at any time to see the current tempo on the grid. Use **Shift + ▲ / ▼** to change it, or tap **Sends** in time while holding Shift.

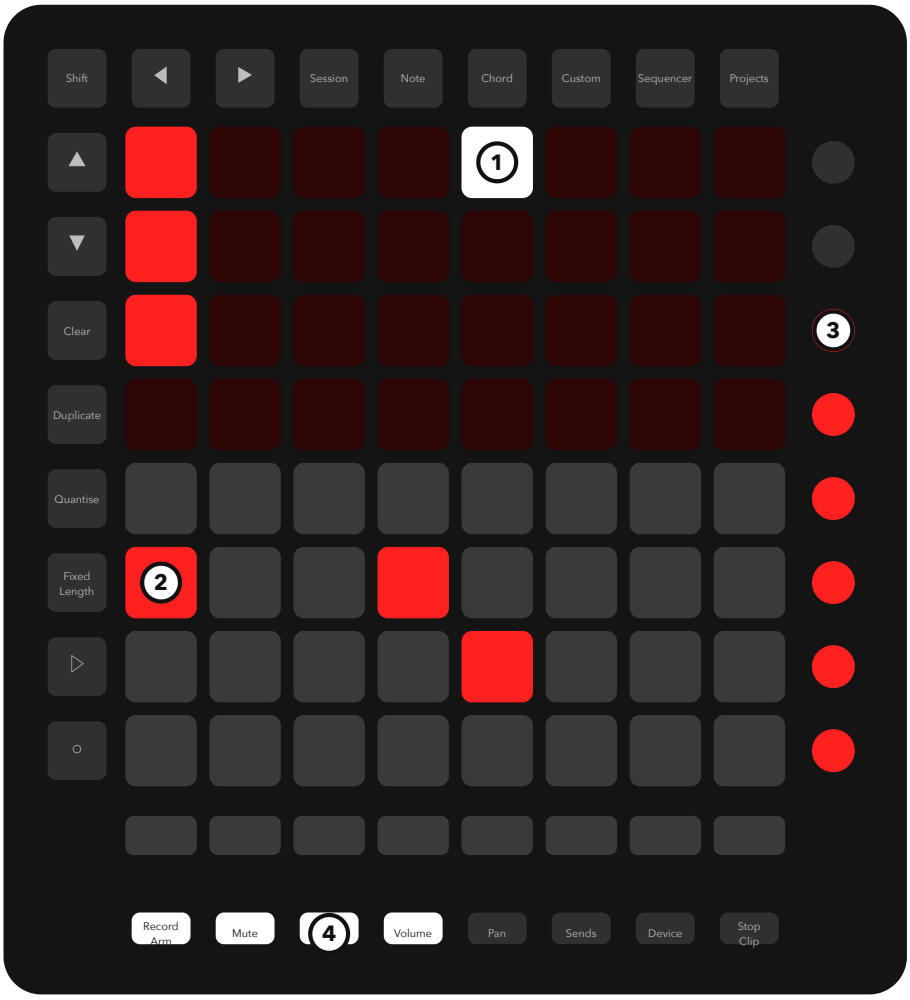
SECTION 4

Programming Steps

Action	Result
Tap a note pad	Choose the note new steps get, and hear it
Tap an unlit step	Turn it on with the chosen note
Tap a lit step and release	Turn it off
▲ / ▼	Move the note area up / down an octave

Holding a step

Hold a step to edit it. While it is held, the note area shows all its notes, the right-hand column shows its velocity and the mute row shows its gate length.



Step 5 held: a three-note chord, velocity 96, gate 4/8

(1) **Held step.** Shown white while you hold it.

2. **Notes.** The first note pad you tap sets the step's note. Tap more pads in the same hold to build a chord of up to 8 notes; tap a lit note again to remove it.
3. **Velocity.** The right-hand column: top = 127, then 112, 96, 80, 64, 48, 32, bottom = 16.
4. **Gate length.** The mute row: 1 (Record Arm) = shortest, 8 (Stop Clip) = the whole step.

Probability: hold the step and Shift – the right-hand column then sets how often the step plays: top = always (100 %), then 87, 75, 62, 50, 37, 25, bottom = 12 %.

> **TIP**
> A step you have edited while holding it never turns off when you let go.

Pages: steps 33–64

A pattern can have up to 64 steps; the step area shows 32 at a time. ◀ shows steps 1–32, ▶ shows steps 33–64. The arrow of the page you are on is white; the other arrow is grey when the pattern reaches that page, dim when it does not, and **green while the playhead is on that page**. To make a pattern longer than 32 steps, go to page 2, hold Fixed Length and tap the last step. Projects saved before 64 steps load unchanged.

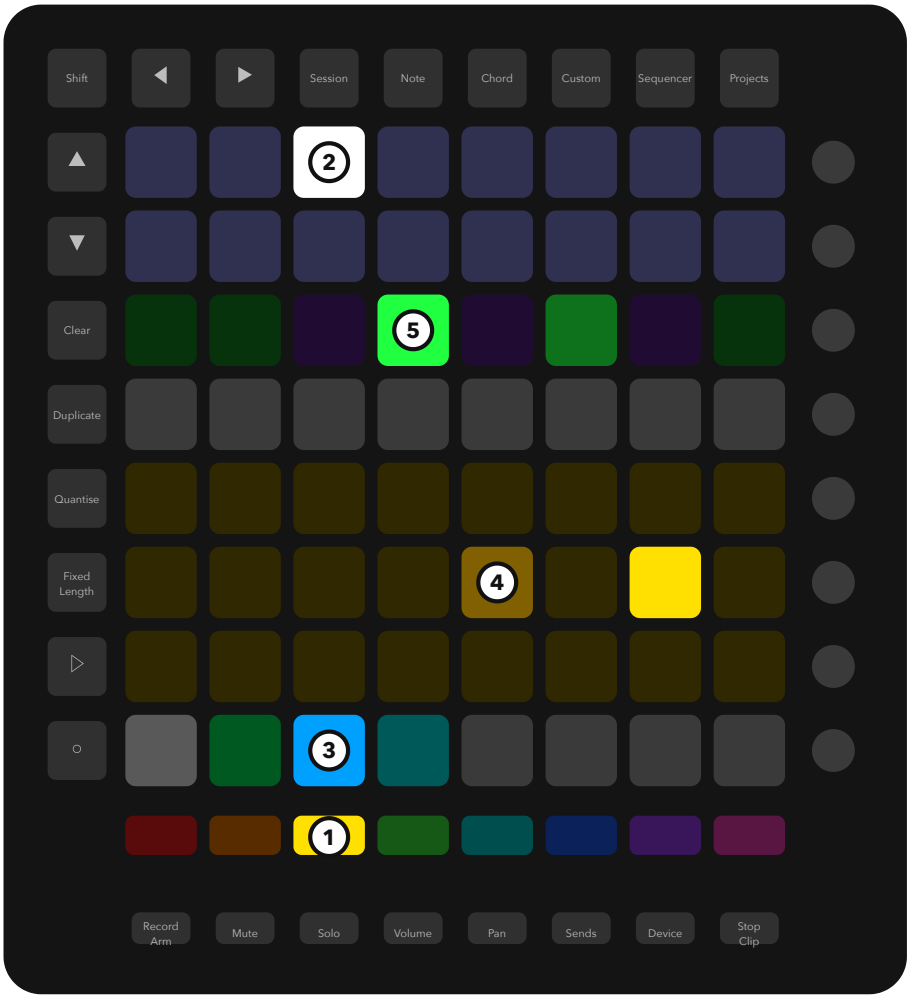
Pattern length and clearing

Action	Result
Hold Fixed Length + tap a step	The pattern ends at that step (1–32, or 33–64 on page 2)
Hold Clear + tap a step	Clear that step
Hold Clear + tap a track button	Clear that track's current pattern

SECTION 5

Tracks

Tap a track button to select it. The step and note areas then show that track, and an external keyboard plays it (see *MIDI Thru*). Hold a track button to change the track's settings.



Track 3 held: MIDI channel 3, output MIDI Out 2, transposed +2, step rate 1/8

1. **Track button (held).** Settings are shown for as long as you hold it.
2. **MIDI channel.** Steps 1–16 (the top two rows) choose channel 1–16; the current channel is white. ▲ / ▼ also step the channel up and down.
3. **Output.** Bottom row of the note area, pads 1–4: USB (white), MIDI Out (green), MIDI Out 2 (blue), both DIN outs (cyan).
4. **Transpose.** Note rows 2–4: −12 … +11 semitones. The dim pad (row 3, pad 5) is 0.
5. **Step rate.** Steps 17–24 (the third row): how fast the track moves through its steps, slowest on the left. Straight rates are green, triplets purple; the chosen rate is bright.

New tracks send on **MIDI Out** with MIDI channel = track number (track 3 = channel 3).

Step rate

Each track can step at its own speed against the shared tempo, for example a bass line at half speed under a 16th-note hi-hat. Hold the track button and tap a pad in the third row; the slowest rate is on the left:

Pad	17	18	19	20	21	22	23	24
One step =	1 bar (1/1)	1/4	1/4 triplet	1/8	1/8 triplet	1/16 (default)	1/16 triplet	1/32
Speed	1/16×	¼×	⅜×	½×	¾×	1×	1.5×	2×

All tracks start together when you press Play, so tracks at different rates stay in line. Swing only affects tracks at 1/16; other rates play straight. Gate lengths scale with the step, and live recording uses the selected track's rate. The rate is saved with the project.

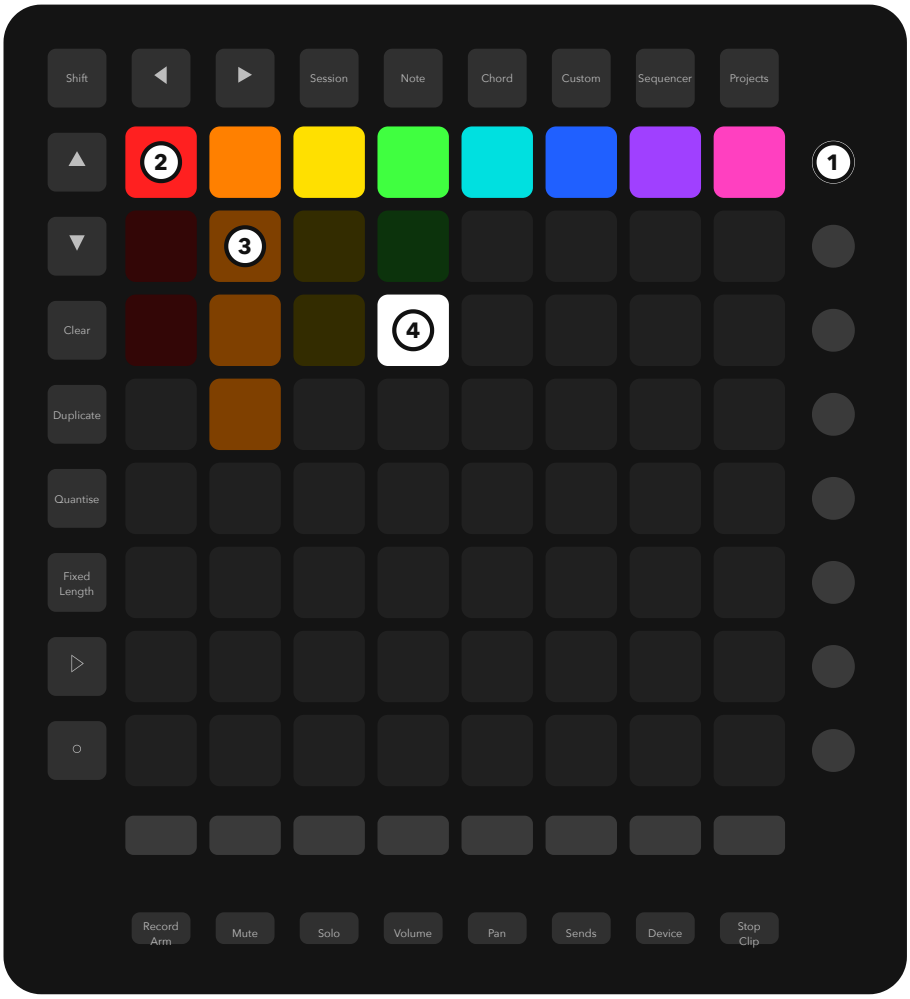
Muting

Tap a button in the bottom row to mute or unmute a track: **Record Arm** = track 1 … **Stop Clip** = track 8.

SECTION 6

Patterns and Chains

Each track has eight patterns, A–H. Hold **Patterns** to see the pattern map: one **column per track** (track 1 on the left) and one **row per pattern** (A at the top).



Pattern map: track 2 chains A–D, track 4 has pattern C queued

1. **Patterns.** Hold to show the map.
2. **Current pattern.** Lit in the track's colour.
3. **Chained.** Medium brightness: part of the track's chain. Dim = has notes; off = empty.
4. **Queued.** White: starts when the playing pattern ends.

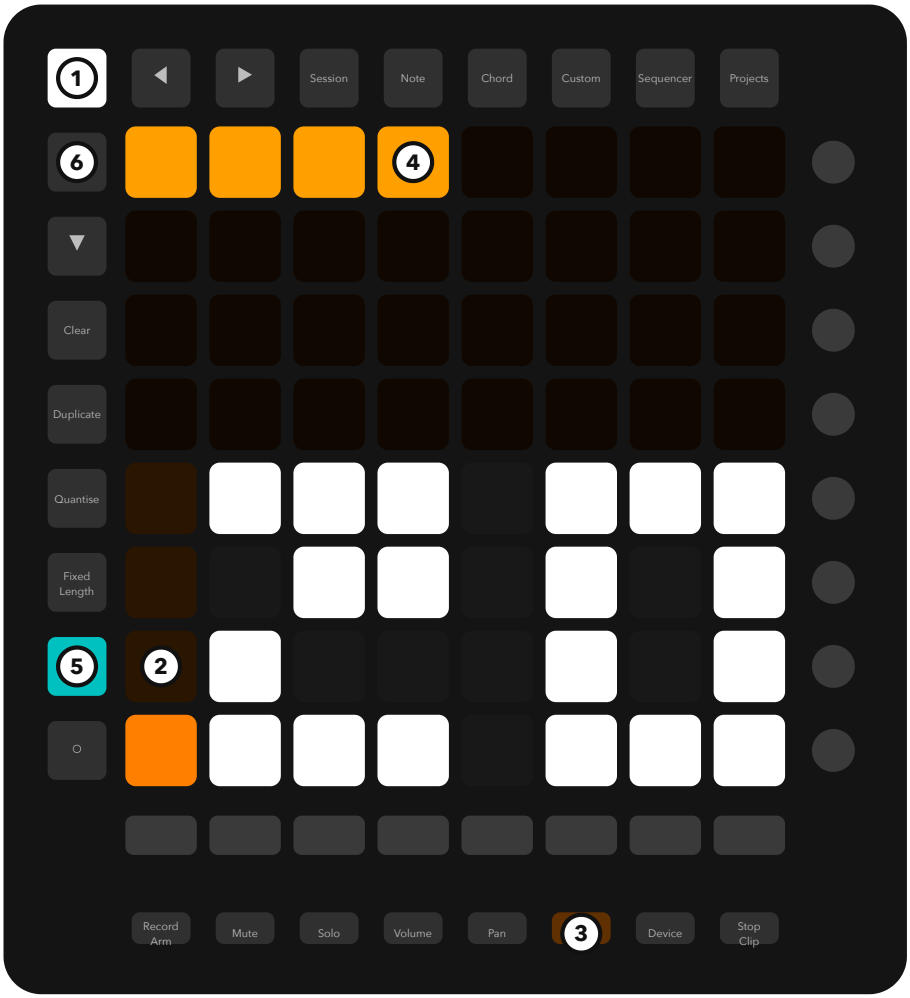
While holding Patterns	Result
Tap a pattern	Switch the track to it – at the end of the playing pattern, or at once when stopped
Hold a pattern + tap another in the same column	**Chain** the range: A–D plays A, B, C, D, A, …
Hold **Duplicate** + tap a pattern	Copy the track's current pattern there
Hold **Clear** + tap a pattern	Clear that pattern

TIP

Each track switches and chains on its own, and patterns can have different lengths – use this for polyrhythms.

SECTION 7

Tempo, Swing and Playback



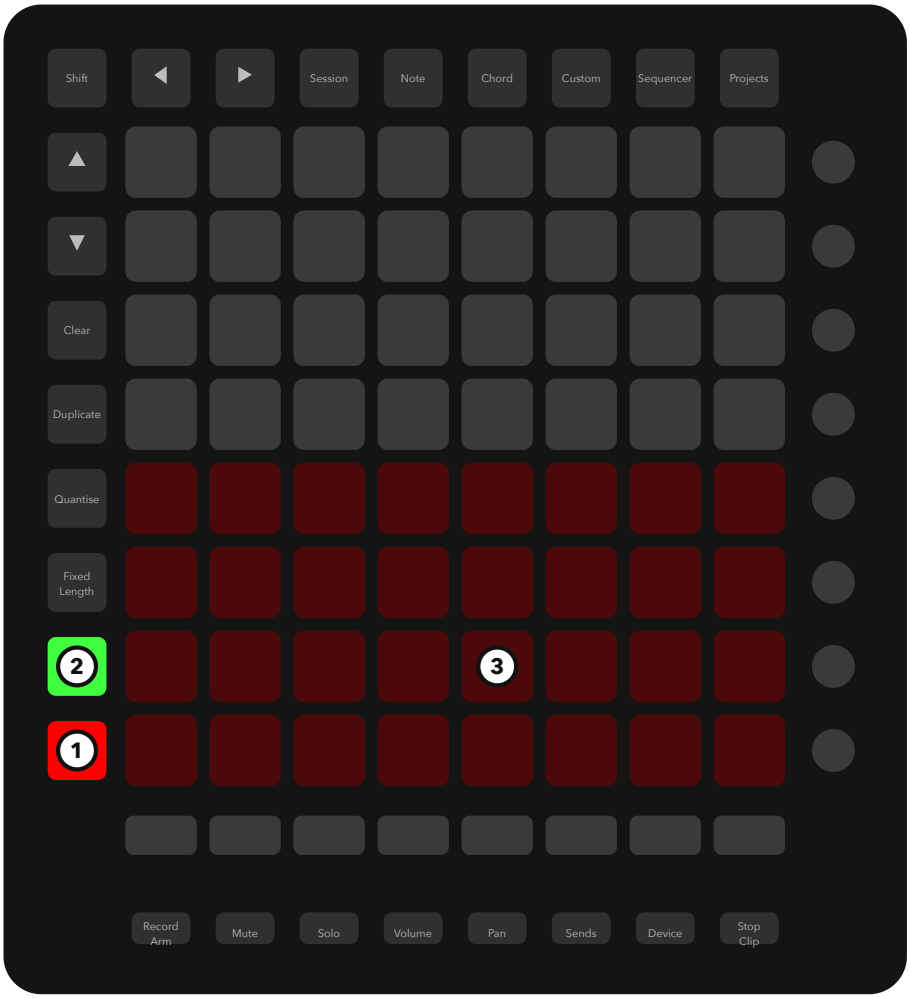
Shift held: 120 BPM on the note area, swing 53 %, Play cyan (follow external clock)

1. **Shift.** Hold to see tempo, swing and the clock setting.
2. **BPM readout.** An orange bar for the hundreds (1–3 pads), then the tens and units in white.
3. **Tap.** Shift + Sends (printed *Tap*) is tap tempo.
4. **Swing.** The step area shows swing: step 1 = 50 % (straight) … step 26 = 75 %.
5. **Play.** With Shift: the external clock setting (see *MIDI Clock*).
6. **▲ / ▼.** With Shift: tempo.

Action	Result
▷	Start / stop
Shift + ▲ / ▼	Tempo +1 / −1 BPM (30–300)
Shift + **Fixed Length** + ▲ / ▼	Tempo +10 / −10 BPM
Shift + **Sends** (Tap)	Tap tempo: tap in time; the average of the last few taps sets the BPM. A 2-second pause starts over. The button flashes white on each tap.
Shift + a step 1–26	Swing 50–75 %

SECTION 8

Live Recording



Recording armed and playing

1. **Record.** Tap to arm (dark red); bright red while playing.
2. **Play.** Recording happens while the sequencer plays.
3. **Notes.** Play the note pads, or a keyboard on MIDI In or USB.

Recorded notes land on the **nearest step** of the selected track's current pattern, with their velocity and their held length as the gate: a note held over several steps plays for as long as you held it. Notes played together are recorded as a **chord** of up to 8 notes, keeping the loudest velocity.

A note played just ahead of a step is not replayed on that pass – you have already heard it.

Tap ○ again to stop recording.

SECTION 9

MIDI Thru

A keyboard connected to **MIDI In** or to the Launchpad's USB MIDI port plays the **selected track**. Notes, aftertouch, controllers, program changes and pitch bend are re-sent on that track's output and MIDI channel, whatever channel the keyboard sends on. Select another track and the keyboard plays that track's instrument.

A note-off always goes to wherever its note-on went, so changing track while holding keys never leaves notes stuck.

> **TIP**
> If your keyboard has its own sounds, turn its **Local** setting off so you only hear the selected track's instrument.

If the keyboard has MIDI Thru switched on, the sequencer's own notes and controllers come back to it. These echoes are recognised and dropped, so they do not loop or record twice.

SECTION 10

MIDI Clock

Sending clock

When the sequencer runs on its own tempo, it sends MIDI clock, start and stop to USB, MIDI Out and MIDI Out 2, so drum machines and arpeggiators can follow it.

Following an external clock

Clock, start, continue and stop arriving on **MIDI In** or the USB MIDI port are followed automatically:

- ▷ turns **cyan**.
- The clock is passed on to both DIN outputs.
- Tempo controls and tap tempo have no effect.
- Half a second after the last clock pulse, the sequencer carries on with its own clock.

Ignoring an external clock

Press Shift + ▷ to choose whether external clock is followed. While Shift is held, ▷ shows the setting:

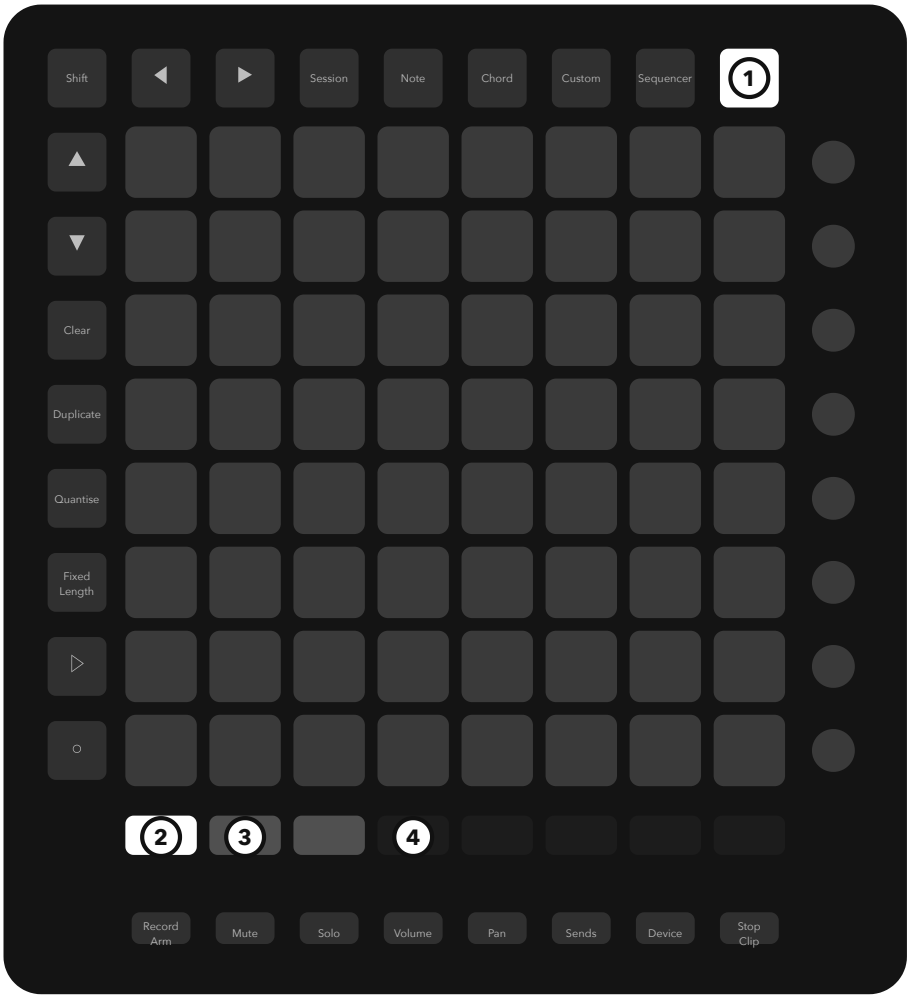
▷ with Shift held	Setting
Cyan	Follow an external clock (default)
Orange	Ignore incoming clock, start and stop; always run on and send the sequencer's own clock

The setting is saved with the project.

> **NOTE**
> A synth with MIDI Thru switched on sends the sequencer's clock straight back. The sequencer recognises its own clock and ignores it, so the tempo cannot run away.

SECTION 11

Projects



Projects held: slot 1 current, slots 2 and 3 saved

1. **Projects.** Tap to save to the current slot (flashes white). Hold to choose a slot.
2. **Current slot.** White.
3. **Saved slot.** Dim. Tap to load it.
4. **Empty slot.** Off. Tap to make it the slot the next save goes to.

The Projects button is **green** when everything is saved and **amber** when there are unsaved changes.

A project stores all tracks, patterns and chains, channels, outputs, transpose, step rates, tempo, swing and the external clock setting. The last used slot is loaded automatically after power-up.

SECTION 12

Quick Reference

Control	Tap	With Shift	Hold + …
Step pad	Toggle step	Set swing (steps 1–26)	Note pads = notes / chord; right column = velocity (+ Shift = probability); mute row = gate
Note pad	Choose and hear note	–	–
Track button	Select track	–	Steps 1–16 = channel; steps 17–24 = step rate; note row 1 = output; rows 2–4 = transpose; ▲ / ▼ = channel
Mute row	Mute track 1–8	Sends = tap tempo	–
▲ / ▼	Octave	Tempo ±1 (±10 with Fixed Length)	–
▷ Play	Start / stop	Follow / ignore external clock	–
○ Record	Arm / disarm recording	–	–
Fixed Length	–	–	+ step = pattern length
◀ / ▶	Steps 1–32 / 33–64	–	–
Clear	–	–	+ step = clear step; + track = clear pattern
Duplicate	–	–	With Patterns: copy pattern
Patterns	–	–	Pattern map: switch, chain, copy, clear
Projects	Save	–	Track row = choose / load slot
Note	Note mode (playback continues)	–	–

SECTION 13

Installing the Firmware

The sequencer is part of a custom build of the open-source CoreFW firmware (github.com/anthonyhfm/launchpad-core-firmware, GPL-3.0). No Novation firmware is supplied with it.

> **WARNING**
> This firmware is an early beta, tested on very few devices. Flashing your own Launchpad is at your own risk: the firmware may misbehave or lose your projects and settings, and an interrupted or failed update can leave the Launchpad needing recovery from the bootloader. The authors accept no responsibility for damage to your device or data. It is not Novation software and Novation does not support it.

Installing

1. Download the latest `.syx` file from github.com/cyberheater/Launchpad-Pro-MK3-Custom-firmware/releases, or build it yourself: `cargo lppmk3` in that repository (branch `lppmk3-sequencer`) makes `build/lppmk3/fw.syx`.
2. Unplug the Launchpad. Hold **Setup** while plugging the USB cable back in. The Launchpad starts in bootloader mode and a MIDI port with "Bootloader" in its name appears.
3. Send the `.syx` file to that port. Use CoreFW's `python3 tools/flash.py <file>.syx` (needs `pip install mido python-rtmidi`), the Mac-only `swift scripts/flash_syx.swift <file>.syx` from github.com/cyberheater/lpp-emu, or any SysEx tool (SysEx Librarian, MIDI-OX). Do not unplug the Launchpad while it is sending.
4. The Launchpad restarts with the sequencer firmware. Press **Sequencer** to open it.

Returning to the original firmware

Enter bootloader mode the same way and update the Launchpad with Novation Components.

> **NOTE**
> Projects are stored separately from the firmware, so updating the sequencer firmware should keep them. Projects saved by earlier sequencer versions load in later ones.